STEADFAST MEN

Lesson 12 · A Man with No Brothers

Transcript · Wes Hart

There you are. Come on and settle in. Uh, I already said hello to one of you twice. Same man. He was gracious about it. If we're just meeting, I'm Wes. Uh, glad you found a seat. Last lesson we talked about a house that never said go, and about walking out without making the door a weapon. Keep that. It still matters. This lesson is a quieter trouble. You can look steady from where I'm standing. Uh, people know your name. You answer when a need goes around. Then the day ends. You lock up. You sit a minute. And there is not a man you would call and tell the truth to. I have— I have lived right there. I had, uh, language for it. I called it a private life. Private meant nobody was allowed in. I, uh, protected it. Called the quiet peace. It was a shut door with a nice name on it. Some of you are young, and you figure this arrives later, when the life gets bigger. It doesn't. Uh, some of you are married, and you figure she covers it. She loves you. She was never built to be the only one who knows when you're sinking. Some of you, the work went well. The day looked clean. You still couldn't say who has you. Look around. Uh, good men. Men other people count on. And a gap running through the middle. So here's the aim. We're gonna name that aloneness. Then we're gonna make an ask. A brother beside you. A man out ahead of you. Uh, same obedience. You go first. Nobody drafts you off a wall because you looked ready. If you fell, the man you could call might still be a blank. We'll look that blank in the face uh, before you leave the room. A name, or the honesty of no name. That's the work in front of us.

One, uh, sentence puts four marks on a real man. I still haven't found a cleaner list. Uh, here they are. A steadfast man stops waiting, picks up the weight, goes first, and works for God's pay, not the room's.

Uh, you've heard that in this room. I'm not gonna walk all four out in this lesson. I want them pointed at the man who has you, and at the man you haven't asked. Passivity can look like patience. You wait to be chosen. You call the waiting humility. Uh, it is often just fear with a calm face. Now listen. A man can hit his numbers and still be passive where it actually counts. Nobody at the job is gonna ask him if he has a brother. That question is his. The ask— the ask does not wait on a mood. The mood shows up later, after the sentence is already out. So you say it scared. The ask belongs to you. Accept that. Uh, set the time. Say the sentence. That is responsibility with a phone in your hand. Courage sounds smaller than men think. It is saying the awkward thing before you feel ready. And God's pay is a life God can actually help. I mean, privacy can feel like a prize. It pays you in being untouched. His pay is a man who can be helped, and who can turn around and help. Hold them on this. If you fell, somebody's name ought to be ready. And somewhere near you is a man about twenty years ahead, living a stretch you've never asked him about. Both of those silences are the same passivity. You don't outgrow them by getting busier. You break them by going first.

Ecclesiastes four, verse ten. If either of them falls down, one can help the other up. But pity anyone who falls and has no one to help them up.

Uh, read that slow. A man can be strong and still go down. Strength was never the promise that you wouldn't fall. The promise in the verse is a hand. Uh, somebody close enough to get under you. Pity, in this verse, is a warning with mercy in it. You can have a full calendar and still be that man. People like you. They count on you. None of that is a hand on the day you go down. Falling doesn't always look like a scene. Sometimes it is a slow slide. The temper. The secret. The distance at the table. You know, most men don't announce it. They just get harder to find. A hand— a hand can still reach that, if a man is close enough to notice. Stay with me. Proverbs thirteen, verse twenty. Walk with the wise and become wise, for a companion of fools suffers harm.

So the man you tie yourself to is gonna leave a mark. Uh, company is not neutral. Walk with a wise man and his counsel gets into your feet. Walk with a man who only nods, and you will go farther down a bad road feeling supported. You know, a lot of us have plenty of agreement. What we're short on is a man who loves us enough to disagree and then stay. That's the brother. He can tell you the truth. He is still there after it. Christ stays the Savior. The Father stays the Father. A brother stands with you on a day you can't find God, until you can hear Him again. Uh, one man like that. Two, if God is kind. A crowd is a different animal. You don't need the crowd to stop living unknown.

A buddy is a good thing, right? He's the man beside you while something gets done, or while something gets enjoyed. Uh, you split a lunch. You loan a ladder. You both show up when a family needs a hand. Uh, keep those men. Thank God for them. A brother is a different seat. He knows what you do when a day goes sour. Whether you pick a fight, or you go polish a thing that was already fine, or you get real helpful and real gone. He can ask about the money. About the way you spoke at home. About the late hour. About whether you prayed, or just performed a prayer. And you tell him. He says the hard sentence once, with love, and he doesn't sand it down. Then he shows up the next time like the sentence didn't end you. I have been very known on the subject of sauce. My text thread can settle that. It cannot settle me. Uh, I learned the difference the slow way. I'd come in the door, set my keys down the same way, and my wife could read the whole day off that sound. I called it— I called it being easy. Uh, low maintenance. What it was, she was carrying the weight of being the only person who knew me. I mean, she is my wife. That is a gift. It was never supposed to be her whole assignment. How many of you, honest, don't have a man's name ready if you went down? Your wife doesn't fill this blank. Go ahead. Yeah. Look at that. Capable men. Still reaching. Uh, the men at your work can respect you and never hear what you're afraid of. A good crew is still a gift. You need one man who is allowed all the way in.

You know what we tell ourselves. We say we're fine. I've said it with a straight face on days I was not fine. Fine is pride that learned manners. We say there's no time. Uh, there is time. What there hasn't been is an ask small enough to fit inside a real life. We say we don't want to be a weight. Uh, under that, a lot of us learned early that needing somebody cost extra. So we would rather go under than reach. We say men don't do this. Men did this long before we started treating a sealed-up life as the mature one. And some of you tried. You opened your chest and a man used what he heard. I am not gonna shrink that. Uh, that wound is real. It can still try to run you. One man who failed you does not get to lock the rest of your years. There was a man at our church, uh, older than me, always by the coat rack when the room emptied. I had questions. How a house stays kind when the money gets thin. I walked— I walked past him for a long time. I told myself he looked busy. He was putting an arm

through a sleeve. That is not a crowded hour. That is a man with half a minute and nowhere he had to be yet. I still walked past. You know, I had him cast as too important to bother. He was waiting on a jacket. The fear dressed itself up as respect. I nodded. I left. And I kept my questions right where they were. Uh, I still think about that sleeve. A man within reach, and I walked by as if he were scenery. He might have said no. I never gave him the chance. A no would've been cleaner than another stretch of guessing on my own.

Uh, most men I know already want a brother. What they don't have is a picture small enough to survive the life they live. The pictures we hand them are huge. A standing breakfast before daylight. A retreat with notebooks. A circle that needs a secretary. A man with a baby in the house, or a stretch where the work is eating him, looks at those and does nothing. So take a smaller picture. One man. One table. One honest question. Kept, not crammed. A plan that floats is a plan that dies. Pick a man you can tell the whole truth, with no paycheck in the room. Spend it on a few plain things, and then pray. What happened. Not a report. The few things that actually counted. What's heavy. This is the one that earns the time. Uh, name the load. Name the fear under it. Both of you tell the truth. The man listening has one job. He listens. Fixing can wait. What's next. Each of you names one move before you leave the table, out loud, so a man heard it. When you sit back down, you start with whether it got done. Leave room at the end. Pray out loud. You for him. Him for you. Uh, some days one of you is a wreck, and the heavy thing takes the whole talk. That is what the time is for. The floor does not move. Uh, without those questions, two men will talk weather until the clock dies and nobody was known. I learned that by failing it. A man started telling me what was heavy, and I handed him three ideas before he finished the sentence. He went quiet. I heard myself. I said, I just did the thing. You don't need a plan from me. I'm here. He talked a little longer. I almost— I almost ruined it by being helpful. Help can wait. A brother stays in the chair.

I knew a man in a room like this. Uh, I'll call him Hollis. Hollis ran the meal list when a family hit a hard stretch. He showed up in other men's trouble like it was his trade. What he didn't have was a man in his own. At home there was a boy who had started shutting a door harder than the door deserved. Hollis would stand in the hall, hand on the frame, and come up empty. His wife said one sentence. Uh, not loud. I'm tired of being the only one who knows when you're not alright. He nodded, like she'd mentioned the weather. Uh, she didn't smile. He sat on that sentence for months. He told me later he lined— he lined up men in his head and talked himself out of each one. There was a neighbor. He didn't want the fence between their yards to get heavy. Then he stayed late to put chairs up, and a quieter man was still there, rinsing the coffee pot. The one who never worked the room. Hollis heard his own mouth. I'm trying to be a better man, and I don't have a brother. Would you talk with me, one man to another, plain and honest, and see if it holds. The man looked at the pot. I water the garden most evenings. Call while I do that. Don't build a program out of it. The first few calls, Hollis reported on other people's suppers. Uh, the man let him. One evening Hollis said, I'm short with my boy, and I don't know the next sentence. The man didn't hand him a speech. He said, say it again next time, and tell me if you caught it sooner. Hollis told me what actually moved him. If he didn't call, the man noticed. Just one man, expecting him. That's a brother.

A brother knows the stretch you're in. You also need a man who has come out the other side. About twenty years ahead of you. He has already walked ground you are just entering. Uh, the younger man

waits. He figures the older one is busy, or that a real man sorts his own mess, or that asking would admit his father never said it. The older man, uh, waits too. He figures a young man doesn't want an old opinion, or that his mistakes disqualified him. So they wait each other out, right? Boys become men with nobody ahead telling them what's coming. Second Timothy two, verse two. Paul tells Timothy to take what he heard in front of many witnesses and entrust it to reliable people, who can teach others too. That chain does not mend itself. Uh, somebody has to open his mouth. Don't lead with a big title. Uh, I did. I used a word that sounded like a job. The man got a look like I'd handed him a uniform he hadn't agreed to wear. I backpedaled so hard I nearly took the question with me. What I meant— what I meant was smaller. One real question. Can I ask you one thing. He said, ask it. I drove home lighter. I had practiced a whole speech. He got a lot of throat and the word so. One question is a complete ask. What did you quit that kept your house in one piece. How did you know a good offer was the wrong one. Or can I work beside you and mostly keep quiet. If he says come by, you go. If he says call, you call. How many of you have a man that far ahead you've never really asked? Let me see them. Yeah. He's closer than the excuse.

Uh, once he answers, bring a real question when you come again. The question is the honor. If you only show up to hang around, he will drift. A man his age has had younger men nod and change nothing. Do the thing he said, at least once. Then go back and tell him what happened. That report is what earns the next talk. Don't make— don't make him your father. He can give you a great deal. He cannot fill the particular hole your father left. Thank him out loud. Uh, be specific. I did what you said about supper, and I stayed in the room. Now if you're the older man, uh, half this room is. You are unfinished. That is normal. Nobody graduates. A younger man is walking into country you already crossed. He doesn't need your clean record. He needs the truth about where you failed, and the ordinary things you kept that held the house anyway. Titus two. Encourage the young men to be self-controlled. In everything set them an example by doing what is good. He will not start it. You make him nervous, and he has decided you're busy. Give him a yes he can take. I'm replacing a faucet. Come hold the light if you want to see how an old man learns patience. Uh, then skip the lecture. Ask him what the work is doing to him. How it is at home. What's heavy. Leave him a little quiet after you ask. A younger man asked me if I had wisdom for him. I told him, give me a second. That second is still open. He didn't need my highlight reel. The highlight reel is how a man hides. I told him the truth instead. Uh, I missed a pile of ordinary nights and called the missing a season. His shoulders dropped when I quit performing. Your miss is often the useful part.

Another man, I'll call him Mack. Mack had been the older face in the room so long he figured his record had retired him. Uh, he was kind. He was done— he was done offering. A younger man, new around there, asked him, uh, what the hard years at home had cost. Mack almost waved him off. I mean, he had the wave ready. Then he told the truth. He said he had given his best hours to the job and called it love, and the house got what was left. Uh, he didn't dress it. The young man came back after a stretch of days. He said he had left his phone in the other room for supper and stayed inside the talk. That was the whole assignment. Mack told me afterward, he thought he was the one giving. Mostly that young man was keeping him awake to his own life. If your mornings have gotten quiet, this is a worthy way to spend them. God keeps putting men near each other and then waiting to see who will speak. You can be the one. Now the younger side. How you pick the man ahead, if you're the younger one, stays plain. About twenty years up the road. Living those four marks most of the time.

Leave the impressive man for the people who need impressing. You need a man still standing at the far end of a road like yours. Watch whether he tells on himself. A man with only wins can't take you where you need to go. You came for the scar and for the habit he kept anyway. And pick a man you can actually reach. If no name comes, you're looking too high. He may be the man everybody thanks and nobody asks. Your silence has been part of his life too.

Let me walk the room. Uh, young men. Awkward is allowed. You are not late. The sentence will feel too big for your mouth. Say it anyway. Waiting until you feel smooth is how a boy stays a boy with a paycheck. If you're single— if you're single, don't store this until a wedding. You already have a life that needs a brother in it. Ask a married man how a house is kept, before you have one. The men you share a roof with can be good company and still not know you. Uh, add the one man. If you're married, tell her you asked. Don't hand her the job of being the wise man. She is your wife. If the marriage ended, shame is gonna tell you to sit this out. Uh, ask anyway. Find a man who has walked through a marriage ending, or a long-married man who will not put you on display. If you've been burned, hear me. Asking is not groveling. Uh, that is courage, not a loss of dignity. Older men, be easy to stop. A younger man is already talking himself out of you. Walk across the room and give him something he can say yes to. If you're in the middle, look both directions. A man ahead you've never asked about a house that got quiet. A younger man behind you you've watched and never spoken to. The chain needs you looking both ways. If the work is going well, ask a man who does not report to you. A full day can still leave you unknown. And if the season is tight, a short clear ask still counts. A text that names a day and a time. A sentence in a doorway. A hint is not an ask. Say the actual sentence. Set the time before you hang up.

Let me say the whole thing plain. You were not built to go down alone and call it strength. A brother tells you the truth and stays. One man, one question, one honest answer, uh, and keep coming back. What happened. What's heavy. What's next. And a prayer. There is a man about twenty years ahead of you. He is waiting on a real question. If he offers you the time, take it, do what he tells you, and go back and report. If you are the older man, be easy to ask, and go first toward one young man. Uh, I hope you leave here done waiting to be picked. The awkward feeling means you found the right sentence. At your tables, three questions. Uh, work them out loud. This part of the workbook. First. If I fell, the man I could call is blank. Say the blank, or say the name. Your wife doesn't fill it. Second. Who is the man twenty years ahead you've never asked, or the young man you've watched and never spoken to. Third. What is the brother sentence, and what is the one real question. The sentence is plain. I'm trying to be a better man, and I don't have a brother. Would you sit with me, and keep at it, until it's real? Set the day and the time before you put the phone down. One real question for the man ahead. Write it. If you're older, write the yes you'll offer. A breakfast, a job beside you, or a call. Get with your table. Do this together. Put the blank on the page. Put the ask on the page. A hint stays a hint until a man hears it. A steadfast man stops waiting, picks up the weight, goes first, and works for God's pay, not the room's.

From this lesson on, that means you go first. Find your table.